

Wonders of the WILDS

Aggressive porcupines and other rare sightings make this book a nature lover's delight

| By Shankkar Aiyar |

How far can the tigers inhabiting Sunderbans in south Bengal swim? About 18 miles. Believe it or not, in the days before deforestation, tigers would swim from Sunderbans to Kedegeree village in Midnapur and attack villagers. Can termites be useful? Edible? Apparently white ants have got an edible and medicinal use. In Madurai and Nagercoil, people collected insects during rainy months and ate them in lean months after roasting with salt and pepper seasoning, much in the same manner as peanuts or beans.

Accounts of tiger sightings on the islands of Bombay and Salcette, habits and habitat of the red panda of Myanmar, illustrated sketches of the blue locust and the faggot caterpillars of Gujarat jostle for space between astoundingly detailed listings of rare plant life ranging from the Himalayan Lantern to the string lily of Khandala; the *Living Jewels from the Indian Jungle* is what ornithologists and botanists

would describe as a rare sighting. The third in the series by the Bombay Natural History Society (BNHS) featuring some of the rarest of rare paintings, drawings, articles and notes by the India's pioneering naturalists (from generous collectors and BNHS archives), *Living Jewels* is as exotic and eclectic as Indian natural history.

Peppered with tales on wildlife hunting, records of what was then called flowering broadcasts, inimitable writing like the one on the valley of Deyra Doon (now Dehradun) and stunning detailing of the medicinal and lethal properties of plants, *Living Jewels* is virtually a time travel capsule that transports you to another world. Every plate of plant life, whether it is the Burmese Lacquer Tree or Ativisha also known as the Monk's Hood, is riveting in its detail and diligently edited description. The informative is mixed with the hilariously amusing, making it a page-by-page surprise. A short note on land leeches, for instance, races from the zoological description, from its habitat to its ability to cripple to the anecdotal where *burra sahibs* caught leeches and raced them on the billiards table. A quaintly written note on the "porcupine's mode of attack" is virtually a travelogue of the times. Incidentally, the quill of a porcupine can be as long as 7-1/8 inches and can be fired like darts that can lodge as deep as four inches into the body. Jostling for space amongst naturalists is Rudyard Kipling's *How the Rhinoceros Got his Skin*.

It is a collector's item, even though it is not a perfectly balanced collection. As there was too much focus on birds in the earlier two books, the editors have added plates of Himalayan flowers and plants. But this time round, there are one too many tales of tigers and cats. Not that they are not enjoyable. Dotted with curious accounts of animal, plant and insect life, the book enthral the naturalist in you. Yet you don't have to be a naturalist to enjoy the account of how the elephant saved the *shikari* from the tiger or the eloquent narrative that illustrates the life of monitor lizards amidst Gond tribals in central India. The beauty of this collection of works is that it is unintimidating for the uninitiated. If at all, it could nudge the reader towards becoming a naturalist. ■



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ILLUSTRATIONS OF THE
HIMALAYAN LANTERN (LEFT)
AND THE SHAHEEN FALCON